

In this issue

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The first paper, by Dittrich, Rönkkö, Eriksson, Hansson, and Lindeberg, is entitled “Cooperative Method Development”. This paper presents a method that combines qualitative and process improvement techniques to propose an action research-based approach. This combines research and improvement activities in an industrial setting. This is, for software engineering, a problem of the utmost importance as useful research requires effective and beneficial modes of collaboration among researchers and practitioners.

In the second paper, by Moses and Farrow, entitled “Tests for Consistent Measurement of External Subjective Software Quality Attributes”, the authors focus on the problem of validating qualitative attributes that are often part of prediction systems. They propose an approach for formally assessing—by developing specific statistical tests—whether the experts’ measurements can be considered consistent based on Bayesian inference, Markov chains, Monte Carlo simulation, and missing data imputation.

The third paper, by Nagappan, Maximilien, Bhat, and Williams, is entitled “Realizing quality improvement through test driven development: results and experiences of four industrial teams”. This paper investigates test-driven development (TDD), a key component of agile methods, in two industrial contexts. Results show that the pre-release defect density decreased substantially in TDD projects when compared to projects not using TDD.

The fourth paper, by Pikkariainen, Haikara, Salo, Abrahamsson, and Still, is entitled “The Impact of Agile practices on communication in software development”. This paper reports on the impact of two popular agile development methods (XP and Scrum) on communication within software development teams and among project stakeholders. Results showed that agile practices improved both informal and formal communications and highlight a number of practical issues.

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Though they focus on different topics, three of the papers above report on industrial case studies. This is important given the fact that studies in industrial settings have been too rare in software engineering research. It suggests that this journal is effectively helping to bridge the gap between research and practice, which is one of its main objectives.